

Age for Art's sake

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The old woman had her gaze focused from behind the thick frame of her glasses. She had a color palette and a set of brushes in front of her, mixing colors to paint a clear blue sky she woke up to this morning. Looking at her, you wouldn't know she has a slow uneasy gait; she jumps up to talk to strangers. Loud, clear, and a tad nasal, she is particular about getting names correct; in fact, she practiced mine thrice. Sally is one of those women who are redefining their lives past their prime.

Park La Brea, a residential community famed for its cultural diversity, encourages intercultural interaction, and offers painting classes under LAUSD (Los Angeles Unified School District) as part of their adult education program. The two-room Art Center in Tower 50 is sans any fancy trappings; it's hot and humid on occasions, with flaky white walls and iron doors, the latter reactive to only strong and practiced push. With few wooden tables, chairs, half-a-dozen easels, and a whole lot of paintings, this one is a different kind. Barely does it reflect the ambience of an upscale art studio, but this spartan center does more than what it looks like on the surface. Sybil Gonzales, educator and artist, who's been teaching art over the past 16 years to older adults under LAUSD, finds this an exhilarating experience. She calls it "pure enjoyment," deriving a sense of gratification that she is able to add a purpose to their lives. Her passion for art is what keeps her going. There are so many students, mostly older adults from median-income families with varying social needs and abilities; it is as much about learning a new skill and enhancing one's self-esteem, as it is about staving off loneliness, dementia, Alzheimer's, or such mental and physical disabilities.

Jennie Ventriss, 80, an actress, didn't realize that she could paint until she met Sybil. Her recent discovery has opened up a whole new world, besides her stage and screen outings. The ABC TV series *Trophy Wife* currently on air, where Jennie plays an old woman, is an interesting analogy between reel and real, as the two have so effortlessly merged into one. Much like her character onscreen, Jennie is upbeat on life. Although she doesn't get to choose her roles, she is fairly happy with what she gets. Her role in *Eagleheart* (TV series, 2010) was that of a cranky old woman, but she is not complaining. Jennie is anything but cranky. She ascribes that to her strong spiritual core, her constant effort to be active and competitive in whatever she does. She loves *Oliver*, her adorable cat, who, she says, has no desire to see the world! Jennie was always fascinated by painting because she could draw well. Getting introduced to Sybil and then taking off from there has been a turning point; she's been to an acting school in New York, and the atmosphere there was unlike any regular school curriculum. She finds the same relaxed, social ambience here, and connects the two for the emotions they lay out. Her voice trembles with excitement when she recalled how she made her first flower bloom on canvas. It was a step-by-step process, slowly she found out about colors and their application. The joy of discovering that she, too, can paint was nothing short of a celebration. She started off with watercolors and moved on to oil and acrylic. "It's akin to my acting. It fulfills my need for artistic creativity. Like when I am not acting, I don't feel I am divorced from

my creativity.” She has painted a violin in acrylic, and she can’t stop gushing about it. It’s one of her favorites, quite likely that she is putting it up for the upcoming exhibit next year, in May.

Older adults, not just restricted to the community, even off it find these classes a refreshing relief from their daily chores. Take for instance, Renate Lichter, realtor and artist, who also worked as a full-time illustrator earlier, believes it’s a wonderful place to share what goes on in the art world. She comes here to engage with other artists; the energy that flows in a class like this, is infectious, and, as she says, hard to create in a home studio. The friendships that spring from here are fun and inspiring. In fact, she has had quite a few long-term friendships coming into this class together. Renate thinks that especially for the older and retired people this translates into a circle of friends and family. “It gives them some structure to their week so that they have something to look forward to, and this is also convenient to a lot of people who live in this community,” says Renate, adding that it takes away loneliness, an offshoot of old age.

With advancing years, social skills diminish, adding to the woes of isolation, making it increasingly difficult to hold on to ties or form new relations. An estimated 121 million people around the world suffer from some form of depression. Women are more prone, twice as likely to have symptoms of depression as men of the same age. Studies show that one in three Americans over 45 identifies as chronically lonely, up from just one in five a decade ago. Echoing this sentiment is Mary Wilson, 78, whose husband passed away recently after more than 50 years of togetherness. Living alone could have sucked the life out of her, but she held her grace even in pain. In the last two years she is here, she has been adding color to her life in more ways than one. Mary spends 6-7 hours a week on a painting, and doesn’t hang up until she is pleased with the whole picture. She compares and criticizes her past work and finds ways to perfect them. “It’s been part of a healing process. I love art. I get totally involved into it,” Mary’s voice softens, and you feel the pensive tone. Her daughter, who’s kind of surprised at her mother’s newfound talent, is encouraging her to keep at it. Although quiet and introverted, Mary is open to new cultures, often traveling to places far away. She loved the *Dal Lake* in Srinagar, India, and came back with stories to share. She beams up while talking about the enriching field trips. The National Watercolor Society show at St. Peters, Norton Simon Museum, Contemporary Art Museum, Pasadena, and Getty are a few places she enjoyed taking a trip with the class, and she loved the experience.

“My grandmother started painting in her early 60s, and it provided her with focus and passion after her husband’s death, and most of all it connected her to a community of other artists,” is how Marion Gerwald, former Operations Manager with an Education Commission, who did not have much exposure to art prior to her classes with Sybil last summer, looks at it. She has now learnt to see objects with a new eye. A sense of light and darkness, and values and perspective has come to define her life; she believes art can be transforming. Like Mary puts it, “Even though we are all doing something different, there is an energy about it. We still have a brush in our hand, a paper and a palette, and are making something happen with it.”